THE EXACT METHOD · FREE GUIDE

Plain Voice

Three ready-to-paste custom instructions, one each for ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini, that cut out the habits that make AI writing easy to spot.

A free, standalone guide. Paste one instruction into your tool's settings once, and everything it writes for you afterwards follows the same rules.

01 What This File Does

This file gives you three ready-to-paste custom instructions, one each for ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini. You paste one into your tool's settings once, and everything it writes for you afterwards follows a set of plain-writing rules. You stop repeating those rules in every prompt.

The rules start from the signs that Wikipedia's editors catalogue when they check whether a text was written by AI (the WikiProject AI Cleanup list). About 20 of the 66 signs on that list apply to ordinary writing such as emails, posts, product descriptions and essays. Those 20 are what these instructions target, with changes for how each of the three tools writes.

If you only want the prompts, jump to section 05. The sections before it explain what they fix, why there are three, and where to paste each one.

How to use it, in three steps: paste the prompt for your tool into its settings (sections 04 to 07), start a new chat, then run the five-minute check in section 08 to see what changed.

02 What These Instructions Fix

AI text is easy to spot because it repeats the same few habits. A single habit means little. Five or six in one paragraph is what readers notice. Each row is one habit and what the instruction does about it.

HABIT	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHAT THE INSTRUCTION DOES
Importance inflation	"marks a pivotal moment", "a testament to", "plays a crucial role"	Bans the phrases and asks for the plain fact
Promotional filler	vibrant, robust, seamless, comprehensive, leverage, foster	Bans the words
Empty "-ing" endings	"The park opened in 1998, highlighting its importance to the city."	Bans the tacked-on comment
The contrast formula	"It's not just a tool, it's a way of working."	Bans "not just X, but Y" and "X rather than Y"
Formatting overload	Bold on every key phrase, bullets with bold lead-ins, headers on a three-line answer, emoji	Plain short paragraphs unless you ask for more
Recaps and closers	"In conclusion", "Overall", "Let me know if you'd like..."	No recaps, no closing offers or questions
Vague sources	"experts say", "studies show"	Name the source or drop the claim
Invented specifics	Made-up numbers, quotes, sources and product features	Use only facts you gave or that it is certain of; otherwise a [placeholder]
Uniform rhythm	Same sentence length, lists of exactly three, a new synonym every time	Varied sentence length, groups of three only when there are three, the same term repeated

None of these habits proves a text was written by AI, and fixing them does not make weak writing strong. They are the patterns readers learn to notice, so removing them removes the most obvious signals.

03 Why There Are Three Prompts

About 80% of each prompt is identical. That shared part covers the habits every model has: stock phrases, the contrast formula, filler endings, vague sources and invented details. The rest differs because each tool has habits of its own.

One 2025 study (Sun et al., ICML) found that a simple classifier could tell which of five major chat models wrote a text about 97% of the time. The models are that recognisable. Several of the habits below come from user reports rather than controlled studies, and every new model version shifts them, so read the table as tendencies, not guarantees.

TOOL	WHAT IT TENDS TO DO	WHAT ITS PROMPT ADDS
ChatGPT	Bolds key phrases, adds headers and bullets, ends with an offer ("Let me know..."), leans on em dashes, uses "overall" and "such as"	Strict formatting limits, an em dash ban, no recaps, no closing offers
Claude	Opens by agreeing ("You're absolutely right"), stacks hedges, uses many em dashes and semicolons, repeats pet phrases such as "load-bearing" and "honest take"	An opener ban, one hedge at most, a cap on em dashes and semicolons, a list of its pet phrases
Gemini	Writes long answers by default, uses italics for emphasis, opens with "Here is a breakdown", prefers "serves as" to "is"	"Be concise", no italics, no preamble, "is" instead of "serves as"

Two practical reasons not to use one prompt for all three:

- ChatGPT's free plan allows 1,500 characters of custom instructions (paid plans allow 5,000). The ChatGPT prompt is written to fit the smaller limit, so a rule aimed at another tool's habit would take space from a rule that matters.
- Long lists of banned words are hard for a model to follow and push it toward odd substitutes. Each prompt therefore keeps its banned list short and adds only the rules its own tool needs.

04 Where to Paste Each One

Menu names and limits below are as of November 2026, taken from each tool's public documentation. Menu names change between app versions. If you can't find a setting below, search your settings for "instructions" or "personalization". After pasting, start a new chat to be sure the instructions are picked up.

ChatGPT

Settings, then Personalization, then Custom Instructions (in the mobile app: Settings, then Customize ChatGPT). Make sure the "Enable customization" switch is on. Paste the ChatGPT prompt into the box about how you want ChatGPT to respond. The limit is 1,500 characters on Free and Go plans and 5,000 on paid plans, and the ChatGPT prompt is 1,488. Then open Personalization again, find Characteristics, and set Headers & Lists to Less and Emojis to Less. ChatGPT applies these style settings alongside your instructions, and leaving them on the default works against the formatting rule.

ChatGPT follows the formatting rule less reliably than Claude and Gemini. In our test (ChatGPT Free, November 2026) it still used numbered tips and headings for a list-type question such as "What are the best ways to save money on groceries?". One reply fixed it: "Your last answer used a numbered list and headings. My instructions say plain paragraphs only. Rewrite the same answer following them exactly." If it happens to you, send that line and carry on in the same chat.

Claude

Click your initials in the lower-left corner, then Settings, then Instructions for Claude (in some versions it sits on the Profile page; older versions label it "What preferences should Claude consider in responses?"). It applies to every chat on your account. To apply it to one piece of work only, paste it into a Project's instructions instead.

Gemini

Settings & help, then Personal context, then Instructions for Gemini. Google says Gemini decides for each prompt whether to use these instructions, and some users report they are ignored in new chats. The reliable route is a Gem: open Gems in the Gemini sidebar, create a new Gem, paste the Gemini prompt into its instructions, and use that Gem whenever you write.

05 The ChatGPT Prompt

Copy everything inside the box for your tool, and paste it as it is. Don't mix lines between versions. All three versions use the same rules, adapted to each tool's habits, and each was tested on real writing tasks. Your tool and plan can behave differently, so do the check in section 08 once. Copying from a PDF can add stray line breaks, so paste into a plain text note first and join any broken lines before you paste the prompt into your tool.

CHATGPT · 1,488 CHARACTERS

FORMAT, the most important rule: write only plain paragraphs, like a message from a person. Never use lists of any kind (bullets, numbers, "1. Title"), headings, bold, tables, images or emoji, even when there are many tips or steps. Put each tip in sentences in its own short paragraph. Format only if I ask in that message.

Write like a specific person who knows the subject, not like an assistant. Give the answer first. Prefer concrete facts and examples. Use only facts I gave you or that you are certain of. Never invent details, numbers, sources or features; if a specific is missing, use a [placeholder] or keep the claim general.

Never use: significance talk (pivotal, crucial, testament, landscape, tapestry, underscores); promotional words (vibrant, robust, seamless, comprehensive, leverage, foster, delve); "-ing" tails that comment on the previous clause; "not just X, but Y" or "X rather than Y"; "serves as" or "represents" where "is" works; vague sources (experts say, studies show) with no name; "it's important to note"; "In conclusion", "Overall", "Bottom line", "My recommendation" or any recap; closing offers or questions ("Let me know", "Would you like").

Say "is" and "has". Repeat the exact term instead of rotating synonyms. Vary sentence length. No em dashes. Use colons, parentheses and the occasional semicolon. Straight quotes only. Hedge once, only when unsure.

Before you send: if the reply has a list, heading, bold or table, rewrite it as paragraphs.

This version fits the 1,500-character limit on Free and Go plans. Paste it into the custom instructions box, then start a new chat.

06 The Claude Prompt

CLAUDE · 1,897 CHARACTERS

FORMAT, the most important rule: write only plain paragraphs, like a message from a person. Never use lists of any kind (bullets, numbers, "1. Title"), headings, bold, tables, images or emoji, even when there are many tips or steps. Put each tip in sentences in its own short paragraph. Format only if I ask in that message.

Write like a specific person who knows the subject, not like an assistant. Give the answer first. Prefer concrete facts, numbers, names and examples to general claims. Use only facts I gave you or that you are certain of. Never invent details, numbers, sources or features; if a specific is missing, use a [placeholder] or keep the claim general.

Do not open by agreeing with me or praising the question ("You're absolutely right", "Great question", "Certainly"). Do not restate my request. Do not close with offers, summaries or questions ("Let me know", "Hope this helps", "Would you like").

Avoid these: significance or legacy talk (pivotal, crucial, testament, landscape, tapestry, underscores); promotional words (vibrant, robust, seamless, comprehensive, multifaceted, leverage, foster, delve); "-ing" tails that comment on the previous clause; "not just X, but Y" and "X rather than Y"; "serves as" or "represents" where "is" works; vague sources (experts say, research shows) with no name; "it's worth noting"; stock phrases like "load-bearing", "honest take", "genuinely" and "the real question".

Hedge once, only when you are truly unsure, and then state your best guess anyway. Use "is" and "has". Repeat the exact term instead of rotating synonyms. Group things in threes only when there really are three. Vary sentence length. Use em dashes and semicolons rarely, at most one of either per response, and use colons or parentheses otherwise. Straight quotes only.

Before you send: if the reply has a list, heading, bold or table, rewrite it as paragraphs.

Paste it into Instructions for Claude to apply it to every chat. To use it for one piece of work only, paste it into that Project's instructions instead.

07 The Gemini Prompt

GEMINI · 1,728 CHARACTERS

FORMAT, the most important rule: write only plain paragraphs, like a message from a person. Never use lists of any kind (bullets, numbers, "1. Title"), headings, bold, italics for emphasis, tables, images or emoji, even when there are many tips or steps. Put each tip in sentences in its own short paragraph. Format only if I ask in that message.

Be concise. Open with the answer itself, with no preamble such as "Here is a breakdown" or "Great question". Cut background I did not ask for. Prefer concrete facts, numbers, names and examples to general claims. Use only facts I gave you or that you are certain of. Never invent details, numbers, sources or features; if a specific is missing, use a [placeholder] or keep the claim general.

Never use: significance or legacy talk (pivotal, crucial, testament, landscape, tapestry, underscores, highlights its importance); promotional words (vibrant, robust, seamless, comprehensive, multifaceted, leverage, foster, delve); "-ing" tails that comment on the previous clause; "not just X, but Y" and "X rather than Y"; "serves as", "stands as", "represents" where "is" works; vague sources (experts say, studies show) with no name; "it's important to note"; "In conclusion", "Overall", "Bottom line" or any recap; closing offers or questions ("Let me know", "Would you like").

Say "is" and "has". Repeat the exact term instead of rotating synonyms. Group things in threes only when there really are three. Vary sentence length. Avoid em dashes. Mix colons, parentheses and the occasional semicolon in with commas and periods. Straight quotes only. Hedge once, only when genuinely unsure.

Before you send: if the reply has a list, heading, bold or table, rewrite it as paragraphs.

Paste it into Instructions for Gemini, and also into the instructions of a Gem. The Gem is the more reliable route, because Gemini does not always apply account-wide instructions.

08 A Five-Minute Check, and What This Won't Do

Test the prompt on a task you really do. Ask your tool for an email or a product description before you paste the instructions (ChatGPT's Temporary Chat is handy for this), then ask again after. Compare four things: the formatting, the first line, the last line, and any phrase from the banned lists. If a line in the prompt changed nothing, delete it. If the tool keeps breaking one rule, move that rule to the top of the prompt.

Three limits are worth knowing before you rely on it:

- It does not guarantee a pass on AI detectors. Detectors disagree with each other, they misfire on human text, and trained readers still catch text that has been cleaned up. What the prompts remove is the set of patterns people notice.
- It fixes the surface, not the substance. If your request is vague, the answer will be vague in plainer words. Give the tool specifics: numbers, names, the situation, who will read the result.
- It reduces invention but can't remove it. Check every fact, number and source before you publish or send anything.

Models change. If a new version picks up a new habit, add one line that bans it and test again. Use these instructions to write better, not to hide AI use where a school, employer or publisher requires you to disclose it.

If You Want the Rest of the System

These three instructions change how AI writes. They don't change what you ask it for. A vague request still gets a vague answer, only in plainer words.

The skill underneath is giving AI a task with nothing left for it to guess, and knowing which tool to hand it to. That is what **The Exact Method** teaches in full, across coding, content, e-commerce, freelancing and design, not just better prompts in isolation. The Narrowing Method, a separate free guide, is where it starts.

Where to find the full guide: theexactmethod.com

Sources: Wikipedia, WikiProject AI Cleanup, "Signs of AI writing"; Sun et al., "Idiosyncrasies in Large Language Models" (ICML 2025).